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Social Media Use

I. Policy Statement

In an effort to promote a broader understanding of the Library's collections and resources, Brooklyn Public Library ("Library" or "BPL") encourages approved employees to engage in the use of social platforms, while at work, on behalf of the Library in accordance with the terms of this policy. Additionally, the Library respects the right of any employee to engage in the use of social platforms for personal reasons. This policy governs communications during working hours on behalf of the Library and non-working hours for personal reasons by all Library employees. This policy will be modified from time to time; all employees who engage in social platforms are asked to refer to the policy on a regular basis to make sure they are complying with the policy's most current terms. For the purposes of this policy, "social platforms" refers to any social media sites, blogs, networks and communication tools that exist now and in the future that allow public feedback and sharing on the web.

II. Social Media for BPL Use

BPL encourages employees to post information related to BPL programs on social platforms. This type of promotion is an extremely valuable method to encourage our patrons to be engaged with BPL's programming and collections.

Oversight
All social platforms will be monitored by the Marketing and Communications department (MAC) to ensure compliance with this policy and style guide (to the extent use is for approved Library purposes). MAC staff will also provide regular mentorship and training to BPL staff who are authorized to use social platforms on behalf of the Library on best practices and platform strategy optimization.

Existing Social Platforms
For existing social platforms, staff managing social platforms on behalf of the Library must provide MAC with all relevant site information, including URLs, usernames and passwords. This will ensure that BPL maintains institutional access to accounts if staffing changes, and also has access to all accounts in the event that emergency communications must be broadcast to the public across accounts.

Departments with existing social platforms must also adjust their sites according to the rules and definitions provided in the BPL Social Media Policy and style guide.

New Social Accounts and Platforms
New social media accounts will be created by MAC. Departments must submit a job request to MAC, who will then create the accounts and passwords if approved, and help departments begin using their social media sites. Neither individual employees nor Departments may create new social media accounts on either new or existing platforms. Departments will be expected to develop a content and staffing plan for the proposed account to ensure success.

Social Platform Selection Process
Not every social platform is appropriate for every audience, and each platform requires a different level of management and engagement. Consider both the audience you are trying to reach as well as the time your department has to oversee accounts.

Before engaging in social media use on behalf of the Library, each department and branch must make the following management decisions:

- Clearly define roles and responsibilities of personnel managing social media accounts.
- Consider the resources necessary for engaging customers through social media. Do you have the staff expertise to relay your message using social media? Do you have the available bandwidth amongst your staff to carry out all of the related tasks?
- Establish goals that align with your department's mission and overall communications plan.
- Define who you are looking to reach and why, as well as how you will measure success.

Goals and Objectives
In outlining your department's strategy for using social media on behalf of the Library, the following elements may help direct your overall goals and objectives:

- Promote specific programs and initiatives through meaningful engagement with the public.
- Provide patrons with additional means to interact with the Library.
- Begin and sustain conversations directly with the general public, communities of interest, niche audiences and individuals.
- Complement and integrate with other communication tools and traditional media for wider message distribution.

Posting Content
In order to maintain the quality and consistency of the BPL brand, any BPL employee or contractor who communicates officially on behalf of BPL on any social media forum or platform or posts on any BPL-hosted blog on behalf of BPL must comply with the following:

- Content posted to BPL social channels should represent the institution as a whole. MAC reserves the right to remove any post or content that does not represent the institution or reflects poorly on BPL.
- Everyone is personally responsible for any content they post on blogs, chats, social networks, forums and other user-generated content sites. Remember that whatever you publish is public and will remain public (and searchable) for a very long time. Be aware that if you violate BPL policies with your social media post you may be subject to discipline.
- Be aware of your association with BPL in online social networks. Clearly identify yourself as a Library employee, explain your position and role within the Library on any user profiles you create for public interaction. You are obligated to ensure your profile and content directly associated with you is consistent with how you wish to present yourself with colleagues and the public. You are encouraged to create separate "professional" accounts for public interaction at work.
- Always add value. Provide information that is worthwhile. BPL's brand is its most valuable asset. That brand is reflected by its people and by the content BPL provides, and whatever you publish will have an impact on BPL's brand.
- Always respect the legal rights of trademark, copyright and fair use laws. Make sure you have the right to something before you publish it and always give proper credit for other people's work.
- Never quote more than short excerpts of someone else's work unless you have secured permission to do so and include credit where appropriate.

- If you are posting an image of an identifiable patron, make sure to obtain a release. If a patron is under 18, a parent or guardian must provide permission.
- Use common sense and good judgment. Edit your postings carefully to make sure that they do not contain erroneous, illegal, obscene, defamatory or threatening material.
- Social platform use on behalf of the Library should not be used to discuss personal issues about oneself or others. Remember, in each of your postings you are serving as an ambassador of the Library. Think carefully about material you post on your social media platforms; if you aren't sure whether something is appropriate or whether something might be offensive, leave it out.
- Do not endorse or promote any product or political cause or give the appearance of or suggestion of promoting a political or religious cause on behalf of the Library. Do not use BPL's social media platforms on behalf of the Library for covert marketing or public relations.
- Do not refer to Library staff or Trustees by name or identifiable position unless you have obtained prior permission to do so.
- Be accurate. If you make an error, correct it quickly. If you must modify an earlier post, state that you have done so.
- Don't provide advice to patrons about medical, legal, financial, investment or other similar matters (e.g., the value of a collectible item).
- If you oversee a BPL social platform, review the comments posted and make sure they are appropriate. Inappropriate comments should be deleted. (See "Engagement and Moderation" for guidelines.)
- Employees who engage in social media platforms on behalf of the Library are trusted to do so as part of their professional identity as staff of the Library. As in the case of face-to-face interactions with members of the public, they will be asked to demonstrate good judgment and to conduct themselves in a courteous and professional manner. In cases where challenging situations present themselves, employees should seek the advice of MAC with respect to an appropriate written response.
- You may not remove any comments on the basis of your disagreement with their content or viewpoint. Do not edit comments; post them in their entirety unless they are inappropriate. If you believe that a comment is inappropriate and should be removed, follow the guidelines below.

Engagement and Moderation

Use of social platforms is a two-way street. Managing social media is not just about publishing posts; it requires responsiveness and engagement.

- Messaging across various formats should be consistent. Refer to BPL's Social Media Style Guide available on the B-Line.
- Check your social media sites at least once per scheduled workday and respond to any comments, questions or feedback if needed.
- Upload or post new content on a regular basis. This will keep your content fresh while encouraging patrons to visit often for updates.
- Social media networks, blogs and other types of online content sometimes generate press and media attention or legal questions. Employees should refer these inquiries to BPL's authorized press officer/spokesperson.
- Inappropriate comments should be deleted. This includes:
  - — Offensive, obscene, threatening or abusive content
  - — Hate speech (including racism, homophobia, sexism) and personal attacks of any kind
  - — Spam and commercial content
  - — Material containing a copyright violation
  - — Comments that are completely off-topic

If a comment needs to be hidden or deleted, moderators should take a screenshot before deleting the comment and send it to the Marketing and Communications department to keep on file in the event that it is needed in the future (such as in compliance with a FOIA request).

Use of Facebook for Individual Branches
Marketing and Communications oversees individual Facebook pages for each of BPL's branches in order to maintain an accurate and updated presence for each BPL location. If branch staff are interested in using Facebook to promote events and connect with patrons, MAC can arrange for staff to take over responsibility for updating their branch page. At least two active staff members at that branch must be willing to post a few times per week on behalf of the branch to keep the page relevant. MAC will train these staff on the optimal ways to promote programming and engage with patrons on Facebook, and will then give them admin privileges for their branch page. Please obtain permission from your branch NLS before you begin this process.

Ownership of Social Media Content
Social media content written on behalf of the Library is the property of the Library. Content may be edited or deleted by Library officials, including posts that violate this policy.

III. Social Media for Friends Groups

BPL encourages each Friends Group to set up a digital presence on their preferred social media site (Facebook, Twitter, etc.). Friends Groups can post meeting notices and fundraising fliers for Friends events and share their activities. Keep in mind that if the Friends Group pages aren't regularly updated, your social media site can give the impression the group is defunct. Start with just one social media site and see how much you are able to post before setting up multiple accounts.

Make sure that one person is assigned to regularly update the site with Library happenings and that the site's username and password is shared with the President of the Friends Group as well as the branch contact.

BPL has the right to withdraw permissions to use BPL-related social media if a Friends Group is mishandling its channels, or if any posts violate this policy.

To properly identify your group as part of the Friends of Brooklyn Public Library, each social media site for a Friends Group should include the following language:

> *The Friends of Brooklyn Public Library are organized volunteer groups committed to support and supplement needed Library resources. Friends advocate for the importance of Library services in our communities, increase community awareness about the Library's programs and raise funds to achieve Library goals.*

Once a Friends Group has been officially recognized by Brooklyn Public Library you may post on behalf of the Friends Group and use the official BPL Friends logo. Prior to recognition, patrons are not permitted to call themselves a BPL Friends Group on social media. The logo will be customized to include your individual branch name. Your group should use this logo on all fliers, communications and social media sites.

Please see the official Friends handbook for additional information.

IV. Use of Other Digital Communications Platforms

Staff should not create accounts on behalf of their branch or department on other digital communications platforms that may not be considered strictly social media. For instance, digital communication tools can include platforms used for blogging, such as WordPress, Tumblr, or Blogspot; email marketing platforms like Mailchimp; and podcasting publishing sites like SoundCloud or Stitcher Radio.

The Library aims to maintain consistency in branding, tone and content on sites like these, and accounts set up improperly may cause technical problems. (For example, an email marketing campaign that is launched separately from the Library's main account may result in our domain being blacklisted by major email providers). Staff interested in communicating to their patrons or the public through these mediums should contact the Marketing and Communications department for assistance.

V. Social Media for Personal Use

Employee Responsibilities

The Library respects employees' rights to interact knowledgeably and socially; however interaction with social media can greatly impact you, our colleagues and our patrons, as well as BPL's ability to build relationships in our community and even secure funding and resources. Therefore, the entire Library community has a responsibility to maintain the integrity of the institution no matter where, when or how they interact with social media.

The following policy statements set out the responsibilities of all BPL employees when participating in any social media forum or platform for personal reasons. This policy does not intend to limit or restrict an employee's right to engage social platforms for personal reasons, though all employees are required to comply with the following guidelines at all times:

- If an employee identifies themself as a BPL employee, the following statement must be included in the employee's account profile: "Opinions are my own and do not necessarily reflect that of my employer." On online social networks, the lines between public and private, personal and professional are blurred. Just by identifying yourself as a BPL employee, you are creating perceptions about your expertise and about the Library. Be sure that all content associated with you is consistent with your work and with BPL's values and professional standards.
- All rules regarding confidential and proprietary business or personal information apply in full to the use of social platforms. For purposes of this Policy, "personal information" means an individual's Social Security number, financial account number, driver's license number, medical information (including family medical history) and other highly sensitive information, as well as, if applicable, information covered by the Library's written information security program. Library confidential or proprietary information includes but is not limited to internal information regarding the Library's finances, future business performance and business plans, business and brand strategies, and information

which is or relates to Library trade secrets. All Library rules regarding Library confidential or proprietary information and personal information, including, as applicable, the Library's written information security program, apply in full to social media, such as blogs or social networking sites. Employees should remember to hold in confidence all information gained from their employment that may be confidential or proprietary, as defined herein. Any information that cannot be disclosed through a conversation, a note or an email also cannot be disclosed through social platforms. This includes interactions with patrons. Respect patrons' privacy and do not post photos or easily identifiable information about a patron.

- Always respect the legal rights of trademark, copyright and fair use laws. Make sure you have the right to something before you publish it and always give proper credit for other people's work. Employees may not use the Library's logos or trademarks for commercial purposes or to endorse any product or service.
- Any conduct which is impermissible under the law if expressed in any other form or forum is impermissible if expressed through social platforms. For example, posted material that violates the Library's workplace policies against discrimination, harassment, or hostility on account of protected classification, that is, obscene, defamatory, libelous or threatening, is forbidden.

VI. Compliance

All other Library policies apply equally to use of social platforms. Employees should review all Library policies for further guidance.

The Library encourages all employees to keep in mind the speed and manner in which information posted through social platforms can be relayed and interpreted (or misinterpreted) by readers. Employees must use their best judgment. Employees with any questions should review the guidelines above and/or consult with MAC and/or BPL's Legal department.

Failure to follow this policy may result in disciplinary action.

In enforcing this policy, the Library reserves the right to monitor social media activities of employees, whether or not such activities are conducted with Library resources, to the extent permitted and in accordance with applicable law.

Nothing in this policy is designed to interfere with, restrain or prevent employee communications regarding wages, hours or other terms and conditions of employment.

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Related Policies:

- Media Relations and Publicity (I. Organization 7)
- Technology Usage Policy (II. Staff 12)
- Friends Procedure (IV. Public 6)